POST-GUPTA INDIA: HARSHA & EASTERN INDIA

CHRONOLOGY AND EVIDENCE DISCIPLINE → POST-GUPTA POLITICAL LANDSCAPE → PUSHYABHUTI RISE AND KANNAUJ → HARSHA'S GRADED SOVEREIGNTY AND → ADMINISTRATION, REVENUE AND SAMANTA → EASTERN INDIA REGIONAL STATE

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW ● SUBORDINATE EXTRA ● APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation q4 and all prior artifacts unchanged

00

STAGE 00 CHRONOLOGY AND EVIDENCE DISCIPLINE

CHRONOLOGY AND EVIDENCE DISCIPLINE | C. 550 CE | GUPTA CONCENTRATION WEAKENS; REGIONAL HOUSES MULTIPLY | 606 CE | HARSHA SUCCEEDS AMID THE RAJYAVARDHANA-RAJYASHRI CRISIS C. 630S | PULAKESHIN II CHECKS NORTHERN EXPANSION NEAR THE NARMADA | 637 CE | SHASHANKA DIES; EASTERN COMPETITION CONTINUES

c. 550 CE — Gupta concentration weakens; regional houses multiply → 606 CE — Harsha succeeds amid the Rajyavardhana-Rajyashri crisis c. 630s — Pulakeshin II checks → 637 CE — Shashanka dies; eastern competition continues → 647-648 CE — Harsha dies without a durable successor empire → SOURCES: Bana + Xuanzang + charters + coins + Aihole + archaeology

CHRONOLOGY / PHASE

- c. 550 CE → Gupta concentration weakens; regional houses multiply
- 606 CE → Harsha succeeds amid the Rajyavardhana-Rajyashri crisis c. 630s → Pulakeshin II checks northern expansion near the Narmada

MATERIAL / INSTITUTION

- 637 CE → Shashanka dies; eastern competition continues
- 647-648 CE → Harsha dies without a durable successor empire

IMPACT / LIMIT

- SOURCES: Bana + Xuanzang + charters + coins + Aihole + archaeology
- RULE: triangulate literary praise, pilgrim report and rival inscription.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — RULE: triangulate literary praise, pilgrim report and rival inscription.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: triangulate literary praise, pilgrim report and rival inscription.

01

STAGE 01 POST-GUPTA POLITICAL LANDSCAPE

POST-GUPTA POLITICAL LANDSCAPE | MAITRAKAS AND OTHER REGIONAL POWERS | MIDDLE GANGA | LATER GUPTAS + MAUKHARIS | PUSHYABHUTIS UNDER HARSHA | DECCAN LIMIT | BADAMI CHALUKYAS UNDER PULAKESHIN II | SEVERAL STRONG REGIONAL STATES REPLACED ONE UNCONTESTED IMPERIAL CENTRE.

NORTH-WEST / WEST → Maitrakas and other regional powers

MIDDLE GANGA → Later Guptas + Maukharis → THANESAR-KANNAUJ → Pushyabhutis under Harsha → GAUDA → Shashanka

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- NORTH-WEST / WEST → Maitrakas and other regional powers
- MIDDLE GANGA → Later Guptas + Maukharis
- THANESAR-KANNAUJ → Pushyabhutis under Harsha

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- GAUDA → Shashanka
- KAMARUPA → Bhaskaravarman
- DECCAN LIMIT → Badami Chalukyas under Pulakeshin II

DEBATE / LEGACY

- VERDICT: several strong regional states replaced one uncontested imperial centre.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: several strong regional states replaced one uncontested imperial centre.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: several strong regional states replaced one uncontested imperial centre.

02

STAGE 02 PUSHYABHUTI RISE AND KANNAUJ SHIFT

PUSHYABHUTI RISE AND KANNAUJ SHIFT | STRONGER THANESAR LINE | RAJYASHRI + GRAHAVARMAN | MAUKHARI MARRIAGE BRIDGE | GRAHAVARMAN KILLED | RAJYAVARDHANA CAMPAIGNS | ACCESSION CRISIS | RESCUE + CONSOLIDATION + MAUKHARI INHERITANCE

PRABHAKARAVARDHANA — stronger Thanesar line → RAJYASHRI + GRAHAVARMAN — Maukhari marriage bridge → Grahavarman killed — Rajyavardhana campaigns — accession crisis → HARSHAVARDHANA — rescue + consolidation + Maukhari inheritance → THANESAR — KANNAUJ

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- PRABHAKARAVARDHANA — stronger Thanesar line
- RAJYASHRI + GRAHAVARMAN — Maukhari marriage bridge
- Grahavarman killed — Rajyavardhana campaigns — accession crisis

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- HARSHAVARDHANA — rescue + consolidation + Maukhari inheritance
- THANESAR — KANNAUJ
- MECHANISM: kinship + strategy + Ganga-doab access + sovereignty prestige

DEBATE / LEGACY

- LIMIT: Harsha inherited a crisis, not a ready-made pan-Indian empire.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT: Harsha inherited a crisis, not a ready-made pan-Indian empire.

03

STAGE 03 HARSHA'S GRADED SOVEREIGNTY AND NARMADA LIMIT

HARSHA'S GRADED SOVEREIGNTY AND NARMADA LIMIT | DIRECT CORE | HARYANA, MUCH OF UP AND PARTS OF BIHAR | PROBABLE REACH | SELECTED EASTERN TERRITORIES INCLUDING ODISHA | WIDER ALLEGIANCE | KAMARUPA, VALABHI AND OTHER RULERS IN VARYING DEGREES | HARD LIMIT

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- DIRECT CORE → Haryana, much of UP and parts of Bihar
- PROBABLE REACH → selected eastern territories including Odisha
- WIDER ALLEGIANCE → Kamarupa, Valabhi and other rulers in varying degrees

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- HARD LIMIT → Pulakeshin II and the Narmada frontier
- BANA / XUANZANG → prestige-heavy northern view
- AIHOLE → rival Chalukya check

DEBATE / LEGACY

- VERDICT: major north Indian hegemon; not a stable all-India emperor.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: major north Indian hegemon; not a stable all-India emperor.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: major north Indian hegemon; not a stable all-India emperor.

04

STAGE 04 ADMINISTRATION, REVENUE AND SAMANTA ORDER

ADMINISTRATION, REVENUE AND SAMANTA ORDER | MOBILE CAMP | BHUKTI PROVINCIAL UNITS | VISHAYA DISTRICT UNITS | OFFICERS, VILLAGES AND REVENUE COLLECTORS | SAMANTAS AND FEUDATORY RULERS | BHAGA + BHOGA + KARA + HIRANYA | ROYAL FORCES REINFORCED BY SUBORDINATE CHIEFS

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- KING / MOBILE CAMP
- bhukti provincial units
- vishaya district units

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- officers, villages and revenue collectors
- samantas and feudatory rulers
- REVENUE: bhaga + bhoga + kara + hiranya

DEBATE / LEGACY

- ARMY: royal forces reinforced by subordinate chiefs
- TENSION: delegated reach could integrate territory and enlarge local autonomy.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TENSION: delegated reach could integrate territory and enlarge local autonomy.

05

STAGE 05 EASTERN INDIA REGIONAL STATE FORMATION

EASTERN INDIA REGIONAL STATE FORMATION | SHASHANKA, PUNDRAVARDHANA, SAMATATA, GOLD ISSUES | REGIONAL LINES, CHARTERS, AGRAHARAS AND EXPANDING SETTLEMENT | KAMARUPA, VARMAN LINE AND BHASKARAVARMAN | COMMON PROCESS | SANSKRIT CHARTERS + FISCAL DISTRICTS + MILITARY CAMPS LAND | CHRONOLOGY, ECOLOGY AND POLITICAL SCALE VARIED SHARPLY | DO NOT BEGIN EASTERN STATE HISTORY ONLY WITH THE

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY	EVIDENCE / MECHANISM	DEBATE / LEGACY
BENGAL / GAUDA — Shashanka, Pundravardhana, Samatata, gold issues	ASSAM — Kamarupa, Varman line and Bhaskaravarman	DIFFERENCE — chronology, ecology and political scale varied sharply
ODISHA — regional lines, charters, agraharas and expanding settlement	COMMON PROCESS — Sanskrit charters + fiscal districts + military camps land rights + agrarian expansion	RULE: do not begin eastern state history only with the Palas.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- BENGAL / GAUDA — Shashanka, Pundravardhana, Samatata, gold issues
- ODISHA — regional lines, charters, agraharas and expanding settlement

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- ASSAM — Kamarupa, Varman line and Bhaskaravarman
- COMMON PROCESS — Sanskrit charters + fiscal districts + military camps land rights + agrarian expansion

DEBATE / LEGACY

- DIFFERENCE — chronology, ecology and political scale varied sharply
- RULE: do not begin eastern state history only with the Palas.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — RULE: do not begin eastern state history only with the Palas.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: do not begin eastern state history only with the Palas.

06

STAGE 06 LAND GRANTS AND AGRARIAN TRANSFORMATION

LAND GRANTS AND AGRARIAN TRANSFORMATION | CULTIVATED LAND + ROYAL CLAIM PURCHASE, CHARTER, BOUNDARY RECORD | RELIGIOUS BENEFICIARY CULTIVATION + LITERACY + FISCAL REALLOCATION + | EASTERN PLATES | LOCAL SCRIBES, MERCHANTS, LANDHOLDERS AND CULTIVATORS | ELITE CHARTERS REVEAL PROCESS MORE CLEARLY THAN PEASANT EXPERIENCE.

FALLOW / CULTIVATED LAND + ROYAL CLAIM purchase, charter, boundary record and tax remission → Brahmana / monastery / religious beneficiary cultivation + literacy + fiscal reallocation + landed hierarchy → EASTERN PLATES — local scribes, merchants, landholders and cultivators → LIMIT: elite charters reveal process more clearly than peasant experience.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- FALLOW / CULTIVATED LAND + ROYAL CLAIM purchase, charter, boundary record and tax remission
- Brahmana / monastery / religious beneficiary cultivation + literacy + fiscal reallocation + landed hierarchy

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- EASTERN PLATES — local scribes, merchants, landholders and cultivators
- LIMIT: elite charters reveal process more clearly than peasant experience.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- FALLOW / CULTIVATED LAND + ROYAL CLAIM purchase, charter, boundary record and tax remission
- Brahmana / monastery / religious beneficiary cultivation + literacy + fiscal reallocation + landed hierarchy

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT: elite charters reveal process more clearly than peasant experience.

07

STAGE 07 ECONOMY AND URBAN CHANGE DEBATE

ECONOMY AND URBAN CHANGE DEBATE | DECLINE EVIDENCE | CONTRACTION OF SELECTED OLDER TOWNS AND COIN CHANGES | REORGANISATION EVIDENCE | KANNAUJ RISES AS A STRATEGIC CENTRE EASTERN LAND WAS | ROUTES AND MARKETS PERSIST UNEVENLY | INSTITUTIONAL CONCENTRATION, NOT PROOF OF UNIVERSAL PROSPERITY | DECLINE IN OLDER FORMS COEXISTED WITH REGIONAL CREATION.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- DECLINE EVIDENCE → contraction of selected older towns and coin changes
- REORGANISATION EVIDENCE
- Kannauj rises as a strategic centre eastern land was purchased with gold

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- in selected records new camps, grants, monasteries and regional capitals appear
- routes and markets persist unevenly
- NALANDA → institutional concentration, not proof of universal prosperity

DEBATE / LEGACY

- VERDICT: decline in older forms coexisted with regional creation.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: decline in older forms coexisted with regional creation.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: decline in older forms coexisted with regional creation.

08

STAGE 08 RELIGION, ASSEMBLIES AND POLITICAL THEATRE

RELIGION, ASSEMBLIES AND POLITICAL THEATRE | EARLY LINE | SOLAR ASSOCIATIONS | SHAIVA IDIOMS | STRONG BUDDHIST PATRONAGE | KANNAUJ ASSEMBLY | DEBATE, HIERARCHY AND ROYAL DISPLAY | PRAYAGA ASSEMBLY

EARLY LINE — solar associations → HARSHACHARITA / CHARTERS — Shaiva idioms → XUANZANG — strong Buddhist patronage → KANNAUJ ASSEMBLY — debate, hierarchy and royal display → PRAYAGA ASSEMBLY — Buddha + Shiva + Sun across successive days

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- EARLY LINE → solar associations
- HARSHACHARITA / CHARTERS → Shaiva idioms
- XUANZANG → strong Buddhist patronage

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- KANNAUJ ASSEMBLY → debate, hierarchy and royal display
- PRAYAGA ASSEMBLY → Buddha + Shiva + Sun across successive days
- CHARITY → piety + redistribution + sovereignty performance

DEBATE / LEGACY

- VERDICT: overlapping royal affiliations, not one exclusive religious label.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: overlapping royal affiliations, not one exclusive religious label.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: overlapping royal affiliations, not one exclusive religious label.

09

STAGE 09 NALANDA AND TRANS-ASIAN LEARNING NETWORKS

NALANDA AND TRANS-ASIAN LEARNING NETWORKS | LANDED SUPPORT | MONASTIC INFRASTRUCTURE | INDIAN TEACHERS <— NALANDA STUDY AND DEBATE <— ASIAN | STUDY, TRAVEL AND CARRIAGE OF BUDDHIST TEXTS TO CHINA | COMPARATIVE EVIDENCE AND NUMERICAL CAUTION | UNESCO SITE | SURVIVING VIHARAS, TEMPLES, ART AND PLANNED LAYOUT

ROYAL / LANDED SUPPORT → monastic infrastructure

INDIAN TEACHERS <— Nalanda study and debate <— ASIAN PILGRIMS → XUANZANG — study, travel and carriage of Buddhist texts to China → YIJING — comparative evidence and numerical caution

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- ROYAL / LANDED SUPPORT → monastic infrastructure
- INDIAN TEACHERS <— Nalanda study and debate <— ASIAN PILGRIMS
- XUANZANG — study, travel and carriage of Buddhist texts to China

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- YIJING — comparative evidence and numerical caution
- UNESCO SITE — surviving viharas, temples, art and planned layout
- SECURE CLAIM: major scholastic network

DEBATE / LEGACY

- CAUTION: famous enrolment figures are estimates, not census data.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CAUTION: famous enrolment figures are estimates, not census data.

10

STAGE 10 SOURCE CRITICISM AND HISTORIOGRAPHY

SOURCE CRITICISM AND HISTORIOGRAPHY | ACCESSION AND COURT WORLD | LITERARY PRAISE | ELITE FOCUS | ROUTES, NALANDA, ASSEMBLIES | PILGRIM PURPOSE | LATER WRITING | OFFICES, GRANTS, TAXES

BANA — accession and court world	literary praise / elite focus
XUANZANG — routes, Nalanda, assemblies	pilgrim purpose / later writing
CHARTERS — offices, grants, taxes	selective documentary survival
COINS — rulers, economy, symbols	circulation is not a border map
AIHOLE — Narmada limit	rival prashasti and exaggeration
SHARMA — structural transition	avoid universal decline

SOURCE / MATERIAL

- BANA — accession and court world
- literary praise / elite focus
- XUANZANG — routes, Nalanda, assemblies
- pilgrim purpose / later writing
- CHARTERS — offices, grants, taxes

METHOD / DEBATE

- selective documentary survival
- COINS — rulers, economy, symbols
- circulation is not a border map
- AIHOLE — Narmada limit
- rival prashasti and exaggeration
- avoid universal decline

HISTORICAL RESULT

- SHARMA — structural transition
- avoid universal decline
- METHOD: claim — source — corroboration — limitation.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: METHOD: claim — source — corroboration — limitation.

11

STAGE 11 POST-GUPTA ANSWER SPINE

POST-GUPTA ANSWER SPINE | C. 550-750 AS CONTRACTION PLUS REGIONAL REORGANISATION | PUSHYABHUTI RISE + KANNAUJ + GRADED SOVEREIGNTY | PULAKESHIN II AND THE NARMADA | GAUDA + KAMARUPA + ODISHA/BENGAL GRANTS | SAMANTAS + LAND RIGHTS + AGRARIAN CHANGE | ASSEMBLIES + NALANDA + SOURCE TRIANGULATION | HARSHA BRIEFLY REUNITED THE NORTH WHILE REGIONAL STATES DEEPENED.

OPEN — c. 550-750 as contraction plus regional reorganisation → POLITY — Pushyabhuti rise + Kannauj + graded sovereignty → LIMIT — Pulakeshin II and the Narmada → EAST — Gauda + Kamarupa + Odisha/Bengal grants → STRUCTURE — samantas + land rights + agrarian change

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- OPEN → c. 550-750 as contraction plus regional reorganisation
- POLITY → Pushyabhuti rise + Kannauj + graded sovereignty
- LIMIT → Pulakeshin II and the Narmada

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- EAST → Gauda + Kamarupa + Odisha/Bengal grants
- STRUCTURE → samantas + land rights + agrarian change
- CULTURE → assemblies + Nalanda + source triangulation

DEBATE / LEGACY

- CLOSE → Harsha briefly reunited the north while regional states deepened.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE → Harsha briefly reunited the north while regional states deepened.

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT | POST-GUPTA INDIA | HARSHA & EASTERN INDIA — ADVANCED | 1. SNAPSHOT & CORE IDEA | 2. KEY CLASSIFICATION | 3. STUDY LINKS | 4. MUST-KNOW FACTS (PRELIMS) | 5. UPSC TRAPS

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

- Post-Gupta India: Harsha & Eastern India — ADVANCED
- Mini-timeline
- 1. Snapshot & core idea
- 2. Key classification / data

ADVANCED DEBATE

- 3. Study links
- 4. Must-Know Facts (Prelims)
- 5. UPSC Traps
- 6. Current link

LEGACY / NUANCE

- 7. Mains angles
- Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)
- The Pushyabhutis initially had their base around Sthanishvara/Thanesar .
- Harsha's reign involved military engagements; claims of success must be tested against rival records.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels